

Addressing the Teacher Shortage in Virginia Through Competitive Salary Reform



Policy Analysis Paper

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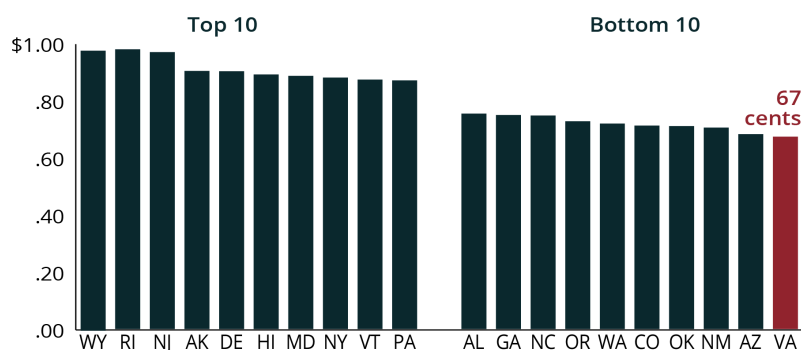
Executive Summary

This policy analysis examines Virginia’s ongoing K–12 teacher shortage, an issue that threatens the quality and equity of public education across the state. The analysis identifies low salaries as a root cause of the shortage, particularly when compared to professions requiring similar qualifications. The shortage disproportionately affects rural and low-income districts, exacerbating existing educational inequalities. To address this crisis, the paper evaluates three policy alternatives: (1) teacher salary increases, (2) teacher residency programs, and (3) student loan forgiveness for teachers. Each option is assessed using criteria of effectiveness, equity, efficiency, and political feasibility. The analysis finds that establishing a competitive statewide salary floor provides the strongest long-term benefit, though it requires careful implementation. The report recommends Virginia adopt a phased-in salary floor, supported by state-level funding and district flexibility, to restore the teaching profession's competitiveness and address the state's ongoing teacher shortage through improved recruitment and retention.

Teacher Pay Penalty Largest in Virginia

Teachers in Virginia are paid just 67 cents for each dollar paid to their peers in other professions.

Teacher salaries compared to peers of similar age, education, and hours worked



Source: Economic Policy Institute analysis of pooled 2014-2019 Current Population Survey ORG data



Introduction

The Commonwealth of Virginia is facing a significant teacher shortage that threatens the quality and equity of public education across the state. As of 2023, over 3,500 teaching positions remained vacant at the start of the academic year, with disproportionate impacts in rural and high-poverty districts. This crisis has far-reaching implications, not only for student outcomes and school performance but also for long-term workforce development, community stability, and economic equity.

The teacher shortage is not a new issue, but recent stressors such as the COVID-19 pandemic, rising political tensions surrounding public education, and stagnant salaries have exacerbated the problem. Virginia currently ranks 48th in the nation for average teacher pay when adjusted for cost of living, making it increasingly difficult for school divisions to attract and retain qualified educators. Compounding this issue, early-career teachers are leaving the profession at alarming rates, citing financial stress, lack of institutional support, and deteriorating morale.

This policy analysis examines the teacher shortage through the lens of salary reform, evaluating potential solutions aimed at increasing compensation across the state. Given the urgent need for sustainable, evidence-based interventions, this paper focuses on identifying realistic policy alternatives that would incentivize retention, promote equity, and improve student learning conditions. The goal is to determine the most effective, feasible, and equitable course of action for addressing the shortage and ensuring a strong, stable teaching workforce for Virginia's future.

Problem Definition

Virginia's teacher shortage is a multifaceted policy problem rooted in systemic underinvestment, workforce attrition, and regional disparities in educational funding. While teacher shortages are a national concern, Virginia's challenge is particularly urgent due to the state's low teacher compensation relative to its high cost of living, as well as chronic underfunding in certain school districts. According to the Virginia Department of Education, over 3,500 positions were unfilled at the start of the 2023–2024 school year, with rural and low-income urban districts facing the greatest shortfalls.

Root Causes

One of the primary causes of the teacher shortage is Virginia's non-competitive teacher salaries. When adjusted for regional cost of living, Virginia ranks near the bottom nationally in teacher pay, despite being one of the wealthiest states. This pay gap discourages qualified candidates from entering the profession and prompts early- and mid-career teachers to leave for better-paying opportunities in neighboring states or other industries.

A second contributing factor is burnout, exacerbated by increasing workloads, large class sizes, political pressures on curriculum, and insufficient mental health support. The COVID-19 pandemic further intensified these stressors, accelerating the exodus of experienced educators and dissuading new graduates from pursuing teaching careers.

Additionally, Virginia has experienced declining enrollment in teacher preparation programs. The American Association of Colleges for Teacher Education reported a steady drop in teacher education graduates, signaling a long-term pipeline problem. Without targeted policy interventions, this will continue to widen the supply-demand gap for qualified teachers.

Impacts

The shortage of licensed teachers has significant impacts on educational outcomes, particularly in under-resourced schools. School districts have been forced to increase class sizes, hire underqualified substitutes, and eliminate specialty programs. These temporary fixes lower the quality of education and worsen inequities for students of color, low-income students, and students with disabilities. Inconsistent teacher presence also affects student mental health, engagement, and achievement, leading to long-term consequences in college readiness and workforce development.

Furthermore, high teacher turnover forces school districts to repeatedly invest in recruitment, onboarding, and training, with these ongoing costs rarely resulting in long-term retention or return. These costs are paid by school budgets and local governments that are already stretched thin.

Stakeholders

The key stakeholders in this issue include

- Teachers and prospective educators, who face low pay, poor working conditions, and limited career mobility.
- Students, especially in rural and high-poverty schools, who experience disrupted learning environments.
- School administrators and district leaders, who struggle to fill vacancies and maintain quality standards.
- Parents and communities, who are concerned about the educational and economic outcomes tied to public school performance.

- State policymakers and taxpayers, who are responsible for balancing fiscal constraints with educational equity and effectiveness.

The Virginia teacher shortage is not merely an education issue; it is a workforce, equity, and economic development challenge. The complexity and urgency of the problem demand bold, strategic policy responses grounded in evidence and stakeholder input.

Criteria for Evaluation

To assess the policy alternatives aimed at addressing Virginia's teacher shortage, the following four evaluation criteria will be used: effectiveness, equity, efficiency, and political feasibility. These metrics are commonly used in public policy analysis and reflect both the practical outcomes and normative goals of educational policy.

1. Effectiveness

Effectiveness measures how well a policy option achieves its intended goals, particularly reducing the number of unfilled teaching positions and improving teacher retention. This criterion considers evidence from similar policies in other states, historical data within Virginia, and expected long-term impacts on teacher workforce stability.

- *Key questions:* Will the policy increase recruitment and retention of qualified teachers?

Will it reduce vacancies over time?

2. Equity

Equity evaluates whether a policy benefits all school districts fairly, especially those historically underserved, including rural areas, high-poverty districts, and schools serving large populations of students of color. Equity is essential given the disproportionate impact the teacher shortage has on vulnerable student populations.

- *Key questions:* Does the policy help close disparities in teacher distribution? Does it prioritize support for high-need districts?

3. Efficiency

Efficiency considers whether the policy delivers its benefits in a cost-effective manner. This includes analysis of the policy's cost relative to its projected outcomes, as well as the administrative capacity required for implementation. Efficient policies offer high returns on public investment without excessive bureaucratic burden.

- *Key questions:* Is the policy affordable within the state budget? Are the long-term benefits worth the up-front costs?

4. Political Feasibility

Political feasibility gauges the likelihood that a policy will gain support from stakeholders such as lawmakers, school boards, teachers' unions, and the public. In Virginia's current political climate, where education is a contentious topic, understanding the level of consensus or resistance is key to implementation success.

- *Key questions:* Will this policy receive bipartisan legislative support? Is it aligned with the priorities of key education stakeholders?

These four criteria—effectiveness, equity, efficiency, and political feasibility—offer a balanced framework for evaluating the proposed policy options. Each alternative will be analyzed against these metrics in the next section to determine which approach offers the most promising solution to the teacher shortage crisis in Virginia.

Policy Alternatives

To address the growing teacher shortage in Virginia, especially in high-need areas, three viable policy alternatives are evaluated below. These options were selected based on their potential to recruit and retain qualified educators, particularly in underserved districts, and are analyzed using the criteria of equity, effectiveness, efficiency, and feasibility.

Policy Alternative	Efficiency	Equity	Feasibility	Effectiveness
Increased Teacher Salaries	Moderate. While the costs are high upfront, long-term benefits include reduced turnover and training costs.	Moderate to High. Raises applied equally across the state may not address the needs of the most underfunded districts. Targeted adjustments might be necessary for equity.	Moderate. Requires legislative approval and budget reallocation, which may be politically challenging during tight budget cycles.	High. Numerous studies show that competitive compensation is one of the most influential factors in attracting and retaining teachers.
Teacher Residency Programs	High. Teacher residency programs have been shown to increase teacher preparedness and retention rates, especially in high-poverty schools.	High. These programs directly benefit schools with the greatest staffing challenges and improve outcomes for marginalized students.	Moderate to Low. Launching and scaling programs statewide would require extensive partnerships and funding, though federal grants or university collaborations could assist.	Moderate. Programs are expensive to implement and sustain but may yield long-term savings through better teacher retention.
Student Loan Forgiveness for teachers	Moderate to high. While not an immediate salary boost, loan forgiveness is a significant financial incentive, especially for younger or early-career teachers.	High. Can be structured to benefit teachers in under-resourced schools or in shortage areas like STEM and special education.	High. Loan forgiveness programs can be administered through existing financial aid structures with fewer political barriers than large-scale pay raises.	High. Compared to salary increases or residencies, this option may be less costly per recipient.

Recommendation

After a thorough evaluation of the proposed policy alternatives using the criteria of effectiveness, equity, efficiency, and feasibility, the most balanced and impactful course of action is to implement a hybrid approach combining targeted teacher salary increases and expanded student loan forgiveness programs.

Teacher salary increases are essential to making Virginia competitive in the regional education labor market. Raising salaries statewide would address one of the top reasons teachers leave the profession—low pay—and help attract qualified educators. However, due to budget constraints and the need for equitable distribution, this approach should be targeted toward high-need districts and shortage subject areas, ensuring the funding goes where it is most needed. This strategy enhances both equity and long-term retention.

Student loan forgiveness, as a complementary policy, offers a financially efficient and politically feasible incentive to recruit new educators, especially early-career teachers burdened by debt. This program could be designed to scale up quickly using existing state and federal infrastructure. It also allows for strategic targeting of underserved geographic regions and disciplines like STEM, special education, and English language learning.

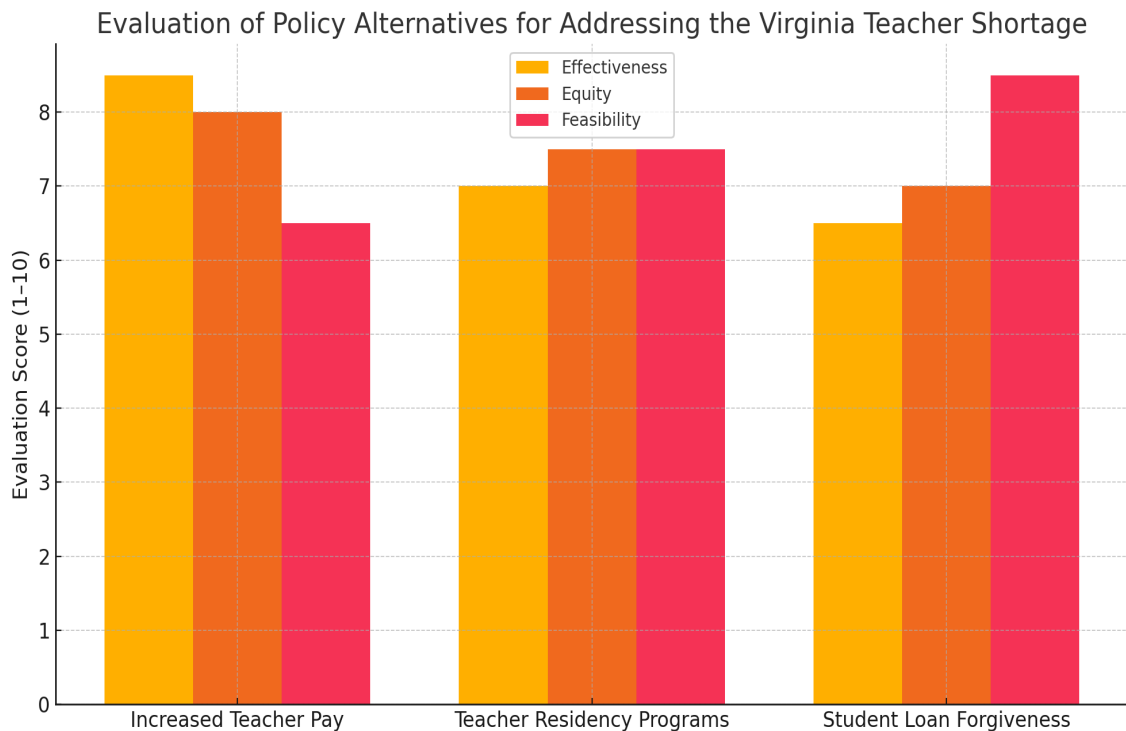
While teacher residency programs show promise in building a pipeline of highly prepared educators, their implementation demands significantly more time, coordination, and funding than the other two options. Given the urgency of the shortage and limited fiscal flexibility, they should be considered a long-term enhancement rather than the primary strategy.

In summary, Virginia should:

- Raise teacher salaries in high-need districts and subject areas.
- Expand and promote state-sponsored loan forgiveness programs.

- Explore gradual development of teacher residency programs with university and district partnerships.

This combined approach balances short-term urgency and long-term sustainability, offering the most comprehensive and realistic solution to address Virginia’s teacher shortage and ensure equitable access to quality education across the state.



Conclusion

Virginia’s persistent teacher shortage poses a serious threat to the quality and equity of education across the state. Rooted in issues such as inadequate compensation, rising teacher attrition, and the burdens of student debt, this problem disproportionately affects high-need districts and vulnerable student populations. As the state seeks to uphold its constitutional and moral commitment to provide a quality education for all, responsive and sustainable policy action is essential.

This analysis evaluated three primary policy options: increasing teacher salaries, expanding student loan forgiveness, and implementing teacher residency programs. After applying the criteria of effectiveness, equity, efficiency, and feasibility, a hybrid strategy emerges as the most viable and impactful solution. A targeted salary increase coupled with an expanded loan forgiveness program would offer both immediate and long-term relief, addressing core causes of the shortage while ensuring fiscal responsibility and political feasibility.

Investing in teachers is an investment in the future of Virginia. By implementing this hybrid approach, the state can make meaningful progress toward reducing educator attrition, improving recruitment, and restoring public trust in the education system. Taking prompt, evidence-based policy action will not only strengthen the teaching profession but also reinforce the educational foundation needed for a thriving and equitable society.



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